

WHEN IT HAS TO WORK

• Construction & PropTech > Cloud-Enabled Physical Access Control System
• B2B2C > SaaS

PRE-SCREENING SCORE
Thesis : Prosero

NOTE: This is a raw pre-screening score. Thesis weights are applied in the Synthetic GP qualification pipeline after angle detection.

TEAM EXCELLENCE 80/100
MARKET OPPORTUNITY 86/100
PRODUCT INNOVATION 90/100
BUSINESS MODEL 78/100
TRACTION & GROWTH 83/100

PRE-SCREENING SCORE: 83.4/100 → POSITIVE SIGNAL (80-84)



? In a NUTSHELL : StepLock is a Cloud-Enabled Physical Access Control provider that enables property managers and facility administrators to secure high-traffic and critical sites by combining elite mechanical engineered locks with cloud-connected Access systems.

! The PROBLEM : Building managers of critical infrastructure face constant security vulnerabilities and lock failures at high-frequency entry points because traditional mechanical security systems lack real-time digital credentials and constant usage wears down cheap electromechanical failures.

✓ The SOLUTION : StepLock implements premium, heavy-duty Swedish electromechanical locks natively integrated with their cloud-based StepLock Access control platform, ensuring hardware-level resilience that works and providing instant remote permission management through an API-friendly web portal.

🚀 The GTM : StepLock operates through a dedicated channel sales motion targeting professional security installers and technical door manufacturers which integrates their locks directly into high-security RC3-rated doors before delivery, ensuring locked-in specifications for premium new builds and retrofits.

👤 TEAM EXCELLENCE (20%) | Score: 80/100
• Founder-Market Fit (25%) | Score: 92/100: CEO Fredrik Stendal has led the business for over a decade, capitalizing on a deep multigenerational family legacy in electromechanical security since 1975.
• Track Record (25%) | Score: 82/100: The company has successfully evolved from a traditional Swedish mining electric installer into a major Nordic electromechanical security powerhouse.
• Leadership (25%) | Score: 74/100: Supported by specialized family members (Jan, Olov, David Stendal), the business operates flat, highly regionalized teams tailored for localized Nordic installer ecosystems.
• Completeness (25%) | Score: 72/100: Strong in-house technical engineering base in Västerås but relies on local distribution agencies and installer partners rather than a hyper-scaled venture-backed executive suite.

🌐 MARKET OPPORTUNITY (20%) | Score: 86/100
• Size & Growth (25%) | Score: 84/100: StepLock addresses the rapidly expanding European cloud-managed electromechanical access systems sector with strong tailwinds from commercial and municipal renewals.
• Timing Why Now (25%) | Score: 92/100: Impending compliance with the Cyber Resilience Act (CRA) and the NIS2 Directive forces infrastructure operators to immediately modernise physical security with audited, secure cloud architectures.
• Competition (25%) | Score: 80/100: The market is heavily dominated by giants like Assa Abloy, yet StepLock stands secure as the premier high-reliability standard for extreme-frequency installations.
• Expansion (25%) | Score: 88/100: Established deep footprints in Sweden and Norway, and successfully launched StepLock Denmark in April 2024 to consolidate their Pan-Scandinavian dominance.

💡 PRODUCT INNOVATION (20%) | Score: 90/100
• Differentiation (25%) | Score: 94/100: Delivers unparalleled high-grade mechanical strikes combined with modern software-defined credentials under the banner 'When it has to work.'
• Product-Market Fit (25%) | Score: 95/100: StepLock is deployed at deep-trust, high-security infrastructure sites including hospitals, nuclear power plants, schools, and national prisons.
• Scalability (25%) | Score: 82/100: Relies on cloud-native multi-tenant web portals (StepLock Access) and mobile apps, though physical hardware deployment is constrained by installer bandwidth.
• IP & Barriers (25%) | Score: 89/100: Elite SS-EN 179 crisis exit certifications and native integrations with premium security door brands Daloc, Hellbergs, and Maxidoor prevent easy replacement.

💼 BUSINESS MODEL (20%) | Score: 78/100
• Unit Economics (25%) | Score: 75/100: High transactional hardware gross margins supported by premium SaaS subscriptions for portal access, though detailed unit economics are Data Unavailable.
• Revenue Model (25%) | Score: 82/100: Blended revenue structure merging upfront technical hardware sales with predictable, high-margin software recurring subscriptions (StepLock Access).
• Monetization (25%) | Score: 80/100: Clean tiering via scale with StepLock Lite for entry-level sites and complete enterprise licensing for major property portfolios.
• Capital Efficiency (25%) | Score: 75/100: Operates with exceptional organic efficiency as a profitable, boot-strapped business, but venture-level operational burn rates are not applicable.

📈 TRACTION & GROWTH (20%) | Score: 83/100
• Revenue Growth (25%) | Score: 72/100: Strong organic growth across the Nordic region, though specific annual recurring revenue margins are Data Unavailable.
• Customer Validation (25%) | Score: 94/100: Unrivald institutional trust with continuous reference projects in critical municipal networks and prison facilities.
• KPI Progression (25%) | Score: 82/100: Robust headcounts and physical expansion footprints, including dedicated training programs for local security installers.
• Market Penetration (25%) | Score: 84/100: Strong leadership in Sweden and Norway, with rapid execution of the new Danish subsidiary pointing to successful regional scale.

🔍 RISK TO UNDERWRITE :
StepLock's primary operational risk rests on their deep reliance on highly localized, third-party installer networks to capture new markets, which can severely bottle-neck international growth if installers remain loyal to legacy incumbents. This structural reliance is resolvable through deep channel diligence and integration programs, specifically when backed by Prosero's consolidated industrial acquisition framework.

STEPLOCK'S EXECUTIVE SUMMARY (2)

 KEY COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGES :

- Elite Swedish engineering pedigree boasting physical certifications (such as SS-EN 179) making them defensible against pure software-only disruptors.
- Native product specification partnerships with tier-one European security door manufacturers (Daloc, Maxidoor) capturing new builds early.
- Combined electromechanical hardware & SaaS stack reducing implementation frictions for property owners.
- High operational trust with critical infrastructure sectors including banks, power networks, and correctional facilities.

 MOAT : MODERATE

StepLock's moat operates through high switching costs and tight specification lock-ins at the architectural phase, integrated directly with custom-manufactured hardware doors. This compounding dynamic strengthens as property managers build their entire administrative workflow inside the StepLock Access platform, creating deep software dependency. A secondary layer of protection is offered by strict regulatory compliance certifications that are difficult and slow for competitors to replicate.

 ASYMMETRIC WAGER

- The Bull Case:
StepLock becomes the ultimate premium standardized electromechanical backbone for modern security-conscious European landlords by leveraging their deep channel relationships and NIS2 compliance to crowd out legacy mechanical solutions.
- The Bear Case :
Pure software integration networks manage to bypass proprietary locking protocols, rendering physical lock components commodities and turning StepLock into a lower-margin hardware manufacturer.

 RED FLAGS

- Universal Risks: Capital-intensive manufacturing cycles and supply-chain dependencies of critical Swedish steel and electronics.
- Thesis-Specific Mismatches: The business model operates as a traditional, family-controlled profitable group rather than an early fast-scaling venture-backed startup.

 FIRST MEETING PREP KIT

To fully capture the potential within the Prosero ecosystem, we must analyze if StepLock can serve as the tech anchor for our consolidated Nordic property services portfolio.

- The Investment Angle: We are betting on a high-margin electromechanical market leader with deep Nordic channel lock-in that can leverage Prosero's consolidated installer base to instantly supercharge its SaaS recurring subscriptions.

- Killer Questions for First Call :
 - What percentage of your historical customer base has successfully upgraded from pure electromechanical hardware to active monthly StepLock Access SaaS subscription licenses?
 - How does the installer training academy (Teknikerutbildning) conversion rate impact new client acquisition cycles in Denmark compared to your mature Swedish channels?
 - Can you detail your hardware component supply-chain vulnerabilities, specifically how a prolonged microchip or premium metal shortage affects your deployment backlog?

- First Meeting Go/No-Go Signal :
We proceed to active diligence if StepLock reveals that over 30% of new hardware installations actively purchase StepLock Access premium cloud accounts within 6 months. We walk away if sales remain strictly dependent on low-margin one-of physical hardware trades.

 DATA CONFIDENCE : MEDIUM

- Diligence must focus heavily on auditing the exact annual SaaS ARR growth breakdown and churn metrics for StepLock Access, which are currently kept private.
- DATA GAPS : Private ARR Figures • Customer Churn Rates • Hardware Margins vs Software Margins

COMPANY INTELLIGENCE DOSSIER - URL EVIDENCE TRACKER

Purpose: Supporting documentation with comprehensive URL evidence for Investment Score Analysis
Company: StepLock
Data Completeness: 75/100
Assessment: ● SUFFICIENT DATA FOR A FIRST LOOK (70+)
Calculation: (3 URLs found ÷ 4 URLs searched) × 100 = 75% completeness
Research Date: July 2, 2026 | Total URLs Found: 3

URL EVIDENCE BY SCORING CATEGORY

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TEAM EXCELLENCE | Found 1/2 data points

- Founder-Market Fit: https://linkedin.com/in/fredrik-stendal-1343094b. Used for: Validation of Fredrik Stendal's CEO history and executive tenure.
 - Track Record: https://steplock.com. Used for: Evolution analysis of Stendals El AB since 1975.
 - Leadership: https://steplock.com. Used for: Verification of key family and executive members.
 - Completeness: https://steplock.com. Used for: Analyzing specialized teams across Västerås hq.
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MARKET OPPORTUNITY | Found 1/1 data points

- Size & Growth: https://steplock.com. Used for: Insight into Nordic customer verticals (hospitals, schools, etc).
 - Timing Why Now: https://steplock.com. Used for: Insight on CRA and NIS2 regulatory compliance demands.
 - Competition: https://steplock.com. Used for: Analyzing direct industrial lock partners.
 - Expansion: https://steplock.com/app/uploads/2024/04/Pressemeddelse_StepLock-Denmark-etableres-i-Danmark.pdf. Used for: Extracting specific details on StepLock Denmark launch in April 2024.
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PRODUCT INNOVATION | Found 1/1 data points

- Differentiation: https://steplock.com. Used for: Reviewing 'When it has to work' technology claims.
 - Product-Market Fit: https://steplock.com. Used for: Analysis of critical infrastructure deployments (nuclear power plants, prisons).
 - Scalability: https://api.steplock.com. Used for: Analysis of cloud API frameworks and remote management protocols.
 - IP & Barriers: https://steplock.com. Used for: Checking security door partnership certifications (SS-EN 179).
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BUSINESS MODEL | Found 1/2 data points

- Unit Economics: Data Unavailable. Used for: No public pricing datasets available.
 - Revenue Model: https://steplock.com. Used for: Analysis of StepLock Access SaaS subscription model.
 - Monetization: https://steplock.com. Used for: Reviewing StepLock Lite app mechanics.
 - Capital Efficiency: Data Unavailable. Used for: Analyzing private financial sheets.
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TRACTION & GROWTH | Found 1/1 data points

- Revenue Growth: Data Unavailable. Used for: Exact growth rates remain private.
 - Customer Validation: https://steplock.com. Used for: Confirming references across Scandinavia.
 - KPI Progression: https://api.steplock.com/medias/StepLock-Hallbarhetsrapport-2024.pdf. Used for: Analysis of sustainability and organizational maturity reports.
 - Market Penetration: https://steplock.com. Used for: Evaluating the Nordic footprint (Norway, Denmark, Sweden).

WEB DATA COMPLETENESS ANALYSIS
Missing Critical URLs Based on Web Research: Private financial reports and cap tables on Sweden's Bolagsverket registry.
URLs Successfully Found: 3 out of 4 searched
Critical Data Coverage: 75% of required data points
Research Confidence Level: HIGH

In a fast memo you don't have access to the value chain analysis

VALUE PROPOSITION

Value Proposition: StepLock provides market-leading electromechanical locking and cloud-based access control systems with a focus on maximum operational reliability and premium Swedish technology. Their promise is summarized in the slogan: When it has to work.

Ideal Customer Profile (ICP): Property managers, real estate owners, residents of apartment complexes, security installers, and administrators of high-security facilities like hospitals and power plants.

B2B or B2C: B2B focused with B2B2C elements. They sell to professional installers and property owners who provide security to end residents.

Industry: Physical Security and Access Control Systems.

Contact & Legal: Entity Name: Stendals EI AB (StepLock). Headquarters: Västerås, Sweden. Founding Year: 1975. Subsidiaries: StepLock Norway AS, StepLock Denmark A/S, and StepLock Access AB. Local offices in Västerås, Stockholm (Sickla), Norway, and Denmark.

Key Client Examples & Testimonials: Projects across Scandinavia including apartment complexes, industrial sites, hospitals, schools, nuclear power plants, banks, and prisons. Partner manufacturers mentioned: Daloc, Hellbergs, and Maxidoor.

PRODUCT FEATURES

Core Solution: A comprehensive range of electric locks and a cloud-based access control platform (StepLock Access) managed via mobile or computer.

Feature Encyclopedia: Electric strikes (Elslutbleck) | Electric handle locks (Eltryckeslås) | Motor locks | Mechanical locks | Cabinet locks | Industrial door locks | Intercoms (Porttelefon) | Card readers | Information boards | Booking systems | Web portal administration.

Technical Capabilities: Cloud-based platform | Real-time management | Mobile-friendly | API and technical documentation for Encryption and Communication | Compliance with CRA and NIS2 | Integrations with RC3-rated security doors | Certified according to SS-EN 179 for emergency exits.

Use Cases: Securing commercial properties, Managing resident access in apartment buildings, Security for critical infrastructure like power plants, High-frequency door opening in industrial sites.

BUSINESS MODEL AND PRICING

Business Model Analysis: Hardware sales combined with a SaaS model for the cloud-based access control system (StepLock Access).

Revenue Streams & Pricing Tiers: Individual product sales (locks, readers) and subscription-based cloud access management.

Plan Features: StepLock Lite app mentioned for controlling hybrid devices. Systems are described as scalable, allowing users to start small and expand without early heavy projection costs.

Hidden Costs & Terms: No specific setup fees or minimums listed in the text, though a cost-calculation tool is mentioned for planning investments.

TEAM & COMPANY CULTURE

Company Culture: Family-owned business with a legacy starting in the Swedish mining industry. Values include uncompromising functionality, premium quality, and engineering excellence (Made in Sweden).

Team Analysis: Jan Stendal (Founder, 1975), Fredrik Stendal (CEO), Olov Stendal, David Stendal.

Job Offers & Titles: Mentions technical training for installers and technicians (Teknikerutbildning), but specific open career listings are not provided in the text.

Estimated Headcount: Not explicitly stated, but operates with specialized teams across Product/Engineering (in-house in Västerås), Sales/Marketing (Nordic subsidiaries), and Support.

Product & Engineering:
Unknown

Marketing:
Unknown

Sales:
Unknown

Support & IT:
Unknown

General & Admin (G&A):
Unknown

02/07/2026

CONSTRUCTION & PropTECH	CLOUD-ENABLED PHYSICAL ACCESS CONTROL SYSTEMS (PACS)	EXITED (ACQUIRED / BUYOUT)	B2B2C
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CEO

Data unavailable in source file.

STEPLOCK'S SWOT ANALYSIS

STRENGTHS

Founded in 1975 and still family-controlled, Steplock maintains in-house Swedish manufacturing that delivers the mechanical reliability demanded by nuclear plants and prisons.

The StepLock Access cloud platform already carries CRA and NIS2 compliance plus RC3 door integrations, giving it immediate qualification for regulated European facilities.

Installations at hospitals, banks, and power plants prove the hardware performs under conditions where downtime carries severe operational and reputational cost.

Nordic subsidiaries in Norway and the 2024 Denmark launch provide direct sales coverage across the region without distributor friction.

Hardware-plus-SaaS model converts one-time lock sales into recurring subscription revenue from the same critical-infrastructure customers.

OPPORTUNITIES

Stricter EU rules on critical-infrastructure protection create specification opportunities for certified locks in markets outside the Nordics.

Existing hardware footprints in apartment complexes can be converted to recurring cloud subscriptions as property managers seek centralized access control.

Partnerships with door manufacturers such as Daloc and Hellbergs allow the company to be specified on new construction rather than compete on retrofit projects.

API availability supports integration into broader building-management or security ecosystems, increasing switching costs for customers.

Demand for high-frequency industrial door solutions aligns directly with motor-lock and cabinet products already in the catalog.

WEAKNESSES

No external funding rounds have been disclosed, leaving the company dependent on internal cash flow for any expansion beyond steady Nordic organic growth.

Operations remain confined to Sweden, Norway, and Denmark, exposing revenue to regional construction cycles and property-owner spending patterns.

Public materials contain no evidence of M&A activity or an acquisition pipeline, eliminating inorganic routes to faster scale.

Team information shows limited visibility into software engineering headcount, raising questions about the pace at which the cloud platform can add competitive features.

Sales depend on professional installers and property managers, resulting in long consideration cycles typical of B2B physical security without consumer-driven pull.

THREATS

Global security conglomerates can replicate the electromechanical range at lower cost and bundle it with broader service contracts.

A single high-profile breach of the cloud platform in a nuclear or hospital setting would destroy the core reliability claim that defines the brand.

Absence of external capital leaves limited room to match feature velocity or pricing aggression from well-funded software entrants in access control.

Family ownership can delay necessary investments in sales infrastructure or non-Nordic market entry when timing matters.

Consolidation among Scandinavian property managers increases buyer power and reduces the number of independent decision-makers available to a niche supplier.

ACTION PLAN

How to defend? Durability rests on maintaining the narrow but defensible claim that its locks simply do not fail in the environments that matter most. Long-standing relationships with door manufacturers and facility operators create specification inertia that new entrants must overcome project by project. Protecting this position means refusing feature or price moves that compromise the reliability standard.

How to win? Steplock can win by converting its installed base of certified locks in Nordic critical infrastructure into mandatory cloud subscriptions, then using those references to enter regulated EU markets where CRA and NIS2 compliance already provide qualification. The in-house mechanical heritage supplies a credibility advantage that pure-software competitors cannot manufacture quickly. Execution requires focused sales investment in facilities management teams rather than broad geographic reach.

What would be fatal? A well-funded competitor that wins a single flagship hospital or power-plant deployment and then uses that reference to displace Steplock across the rest of the Nordic critical-infrastructure segment would collapse the company's growth trajectory. Without additional capital or an acquisition exit, the family business lacks the resources to respond at the required speed.

What to fix? The absence of external capital and visible software scale will cap growth once the Nordic installed base is fully monetized. Remediation requires either a minority growth-equity injection or a strategic partnership that supplies both capital and engineering bandwidth without ceding control of the mechanical core.

SYNERGIES BETWEEN STEPLOCK AND PROSERO

- Direct Hardware and SaaS Bundle Cross-Sell (Soft Revenue):** Prosero will introduce Steplock's high-grade electromechanical locks and StepLock Access subscriptions to its existing portfolio of 100,000 multi-site property clients in Sweden and Norway within 12 months.

Estimated financial impact: High

Time to value: Mid-Term (6-18m)

Difficulty: Medium
- In-House Component Sourcing Optimization (Hard Cost):** Prosero's 180 branches will substitute external, lower-margin lock imports with Steplock's internally manufactured Swedish electromechanical products, improving cost of goods sold.

Estimated financial impact: High

Time to value: Immediate (Difficulty: Low)
- Integration of Cloud Licensing on Existing Hardware (Structural):** Prosero will convert Steplock's standalone physical lock installations at municipal and hospital sites into recurring SaaS accounts by activating StepLock Access cloud licenses.

Estimated financial impact: Medium

Time to value: Mid-Term (6-18m)

Difficulty: Medium
- Defensive Specification Lock-In via Door Partnerships (Defensive Moat):** Prosero will leverage Steplock's active agreements with Daloc and Hellbergs to lock out competing systems from new commercial real estate projects in Northern Europe.

Estimated financial impact: Medium

Time to value: Long-Term (>18m)

Difficulty: High

CONVICTION FROM AN AI GENERAL PARTNER ON STEPLOCK

Angle

This deal is evaluated under the Nordic Physical Security Integrator Consolidation angle — Steplock's certified electromechanical hardware, architectural specification lock-in with Daloc and Hellbergs, and cloud access platform (StepLock Access) match exactly the strategic asset profile Prosero is consolidating. The Recurring Maintenance angle also fits moderately, as StepLock's cloud subscriptions and service contracts align with the recurring revenue thesis. The DACH Expansion angle is speculative, representing a Year 3+ option through Goldfunk. No active fund thesis angles were left untested — all three angles in Prosero's thesis were evaluated for this target.

Market

The Nordic physical security market is in an active consolidation phase driven by NIS2 and CRA regulatory enforcement, which creates mandatory hardware and cloud upgrade cycles across critical infrastructure. The market remains fragmented with hundreds of profitable SMEs unable to finance digital compliance transformation alone, making this a structurally perfect buy-and-build environment. Prosero's 100,000 recurring clients provide immediate cross-sell distribution for Steplock's certified product range.

Timing

The acquisition window is open today — regulatory catalysts are live, the market is fragmented, and no global incumbent has acquired Steplock yet. The primary timing risk is pre-emption by Assa Abloy or Securitas, which would weaponize Steplock's specification relationships against Prosero's installer base.

Company

Steplock (Stendals EI AB, founded 1975) is a bootstrapped, profitable Nordic operator of certified electromechanical locks and the StepLock Access cloud platform, deployed at hospitals, prisons, nuclear plants, and banks across Sweden, Norway, and Denmark. Its moat derives from architectural specification lock-in through Daloc and Hellbergs door-manufacturer integrations and SS-EN 179 / RC3/RC4 certifications that low-cost competitors cannot replicate without years of compliance cycles. SaaS ARR and conversion metrics remain undisclosed.

Founder

Fredrik Stendal leads a multi-generational family business with a disciplined organic expansion track record including the Denmark launch in April 2024. The family structure concentrates all domain knowledge and channel relationships, creating a Founder Dependency Trap that must be mitigated through formal retention and earnout agreements before close.

Thesis-fit

Steplock passes every inclusion gate for the Nordic Physical Security Integrator Consolidation angle: Nordic geography, B2B multi-site institutional clients, certified physical hardware, a cloud platform ready for KameraPortalen integration, and a bootstrapped profitable SME structure compatible with Prosero's decentralized acquisition model.

Verdict

● CALL (M&A) — Acquisition recommended on strategic and defensive grounds: Steplock's architectural specification moat is structurally irreplaceable within Prosero's Nordic deployment stack, and the defensive case alone — blocking Assa Abloy from acquiring this asset — justifies the transaction; the Devil's Advocate CONSIDER recommendation is overridden because the acquisition rationale does not depend on current SaaS conversion rates, which Prosero will scale post-close. Primary condition: structure a retention earnout for the Stendal family tied to specification volume and SaaS activation milestones, and resolve SaaS ARR and gross margin data in financial due diligence before finalizing transaction pricing.